parties that were not decertified for the purpose of establishing a constitutional convention. The first convention consisted of 702 delegates of which only 14 percent won seats in the May 1990 elections. The constitutional drafting process was delayed and a clear timetable seemed to be a low priority. The process moved forward at an extremely slow pace and many participants felt that the entire effort was not taken seriously. Many observers speculate that the rationale behind the gradual movement was to wear down the opposition so that the tatmadaw could consolidate control.

The basic principles emphasized by the national convention in September 1993 included the clear establishment of a union system with seven regions and seven states. Furthermore, self-administered regions were established for national races. Multiparty democracy with a president that would serve as both head of state and head of government would be instituted. A bicameral legislature, supreme court, and clear separation of powers would be implemented. Finally, a free-market economic system with a nonaligned foreign policy would be emphasized.

The role of the military in the new governmental system was the most significant element, however. Twenty-five percent of the legislative seats were reserved for the military. The tatmadaw would also have significant influence in the selection of the president and the government would have no control over military decision making. Even with these obvious pro-military decrees being passed, it was clear that a new government would not be established for a considerable period of time.

The military control was put in a bit of turmoil in 1992. Saw Maung conducted a purge of the government with nearly 15,000 civil servants losing their positions. He was to serve for 18 months with Than Shwe as his deputy. Diplomats that met Than Shwe recall him as being very quiet while attending meetings. He was difficult to read and it was impossible to discern whether he agreed with the decisions being implemented by Saw Maung.

It was also apparent that Saw Maung's health, both physically and mentally, was in sharp decline. Several accounts from diplomats inside and outside of Myanmar claim that Saw Maung was “more than a little deranged.” His erratic and unstable behavior concerned fellow members of